them with promises of cabinet berths and other allurements as a quid pro quo for switching sides. Nitish also hinted at this on August 9 when, without taking RCP's name, he spoke intriguingly about receiving "*soochnayein*" (feedback) and how a man he had helped go places was now taking his "training" elsewhere. The JD(U) brains trust read the moves as advance warnings of an Eknath Shinde-type operation in the offing. It was not to be taken lightly. RCP, a former IAS officer whom Nitish had handpicked as his principal secretary after taking over as CM in 2005 and then sent to the Rajya Sabha in 2010 and 2016, ticked all the boxes. After the 2020 assembly polls, Nitish had made him the JD(U) national president, and he apparently used his position to get close to the BJP—thus securing a cabinet berth in July 2021. When Nitish denied him a third term in the Rajya Sabha, he was forced to resign from the Modi cabinet last month. But signs of greater ambition were soon in plain sight—of late, his supporters had even taken to raising slogans like '*Bihar ka CM kaisa ho, RCP Singh jaisa ho*' (Bihar needs a CM like RCP). The caste box had a tick too: like Nitish, RCP was a Kurmi.

The BJP's own desire for growth was never a secret. Sushil Modi and Nand Kishore Yadav, men who exemplified the pacifist partnership of old, had been shunted out. Nitish had no one in the BJP to turn to. Shah confidant Bhikhubhai Dalsaniya, a Gujarati pracharak, was made the state unit's general secretary (organisation)—something Nitish read as a sign of greater control from Delhi. And the new deputy CMs were lightweights: Tarkishore Prasad did make some efforts at dialogue, but Renu Devi just did not have the matching stature or wavelength to engage with Nitish. As for Jaiswal and Speaker Vijay Kumar Sinha, they typified the new aggression. The predatory approach was on show in March, as the BJP poached all three MLAs of Vikassheel Insaan Party to temporarily become the single largest party, with 77 MLAs in the assembly. (Tejashwi inducted four AIMIM MLAs in June to become No. 1 again.) In June came the Maharashtra episode. More straws in the wind floated in on July 27, when West Bengal police caught three Jharkhand MLAs with Rs 49.37 lakh cash—and talk of a botched 'Operation Lotus' filled the air. Finally, during the two-day joint national executive on July 30-31, Nadda chose Patna as the venue to declare that regional parties would be finished in times to come. Though

THE BJP MAY HAVE TO RE-EXAMINE ITS AGGRESSIVE POLICY TOWARDS ALLIES—IN THE PAST EIGHT YEARS, THE NDA HAS SEEN A STRING OF EXITS

WHERE DOES THE BJP GO FROM HERE?



ANI

HAPPY/ANGRY Bihar BJP chieftains stage a dharna in Patna, August 10

↘ **A SECTION OF BJP** leaders describes the separation as a blessing in disguise, as the saffron party will have an opportunity to expand

↘ **THOUGH THE BJP** has grown from strength to strength in Bihar, it has proved no match to the combined might of Lalu and Nitish, as was proved in the 2015 assembly polls

↘ **WITH LALU AND NITISH** having strong OBC-Muslim and EBC-Mahadalit consolidation in their favour, the BJP seems yet to decide whether to pursue aggressive Hindutva and hypernationalism or change tack to aggressive backward politics

↘ **HAVING CHANGED ITS ENTIRE** Bihar team after the 2020 polls—apart from retaining just one minister from the previous cabinet—the BJP will have to make a difficult choice—whether to bring back old but trusted hands like Sushil Modi back to Bihar or continue with the new, aggressive lot that has failed to deliver

↘ **THE BJP IS LEFT** with just the two Paswans—Union minister Pashupati Kumar Paras and his estranged nephew Chirag Paswan—as allies in Bihar. The two Paswans have no presence in the assembly.